

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Project Management English

Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For project managers, program managers, PMO staff, scrum masters, delivery leads, operations managers, and cross-functional coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Project Charter and Scope Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

03 Risk Register and Issue Escalation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

04 Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

05 Change Requests and Scope Creep

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

06 Status Reporting and Executive Updates

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

07 Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Post-Implementation Review

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | Speak and respond

Give two minutes of preparation. Run the partner exchange, switch roles, and add the follow-up challenge. Observe whether the listener can act on the message.

35-47 minutes | Write for a real reader

Learners write the short message using only case facts. Partners check clarity, certainty, and the requested next step.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, shorten the first conversation and assign writing for follow-up. For 90 minutes, add 15 minutes for a second case and 15 minutes for the final challenge. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Project Charter and Scope Definition

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A sponsor requests a dashboard but the brief does not define users, decisions, or excluded features.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: charter, scope, assumption, exclusion.

Model response

Who will use the dashboard, and what decision should it support? Let's agree on those needs and the exclusions before we estimate the work or call the scope complete.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Schedule, Critical Path, and Dependencies

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A testing task is three days late and blocks the release rehearsal. Other work is on schedule.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: critical path, dependency, milestone, buffer.

Model response

Testing is three days late and is blocking the release rehearsal. Other tasks remain on schedule. I'll show the dependency and the proposed recovery options in the schedule update.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. A - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Risk Register and Issue Escalation

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A risk register still lists a supplier delay as a possibility, although the supplier has confirmed it will miss the delivery date.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: risk register, issue log, mitigation, owner.

Model response

The delay is now a confirmed issue, not only a future risk. I'll update its status and ask the responsible owner to document the impact and next action.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Stakeholder Alignment and Governance

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

A project meeting ends with several recommendations but no indication of who approves the change.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: governance, RACI, decision rights, steering committee.

Model response

We have a recommendation, but approval is still outstanding. Who has authority to approve this change, and what information do they need? I'll record the decision route in the meeting notes.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. B - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. A - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Change Requests and Scope Creep

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

CASE

A sponsor asks for a new report two weeks before launch. The team can add it only by moving another feature or extending the schedule.

Teach this move

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Vocabulary to check: change request, scope creep, impact analysis, baseline.

Model response

We can assess the new report as a scope change. To include it, we would need to move another feature or extend the schedule. Which tradeoff should we develop for review?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. For an ordinary future condition, the if-clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Second-round challenge

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Language-check answers

1. A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule. The if-clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.
2. C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope. This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Status Reporting and Executive Updates

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A project is labeled green despite an unresolved dependency that threatens its planned date. The reporting criteria require material threats to be visible.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: status report, RAG status, trend, decision ask.

Model response

The current label does not show the unresolved dependency. I'll report the delivery threat, its impact, and the decision needed so the status reflects the agreed criteria.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Vendor and Cross-Functional Delivery

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A vendor says a deliverable is complete, but the team cannot find evidence for two acceptance criteria.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: deliverable, acceptance criteria, SLA, escalation.

Model response

Could you provide the evidence for these two criteria or identify any outstanding work? We need to review the deliverable against the agreed criteria before confirming acceptance.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Post-Implementation Review

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

A project review repeatedly says "communication was poor." The team has no concrete improvement action.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: postmortem, lesson learned, root cause, action item.

Model response

Which message or handoff caused difficulty, and what happened as a result? Let's turn that example into a specific change, assign an owner, and decide how we will check whether it helped.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. C - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.